my program had failed, my honeymoon with Congress was over, and I'd have to give up everything I'd fought for during that first year. Public opinion polls showed that a lot of Americans agreed with that; they blamed us, not the Carter administration, for the recession.

My memories of the Great Depression were too personal and too vivid for me not to feel great sadness and compassion for those Americans who were out of work; having experienced those devastating days during the 1930s, I knew what it was like to be deprived of a paycheck and the pride of earning one, to watch the pain on the face of a loved one who had lost a farm or a store.

I prayed a lot during this period, not only for the country and the people who were out of work, but for help and guidance in doing the right thing so that I would be able to justify the faith Americans had placed in my hands the previous November.

In my inaugural address, I'd said America was on the threshold of "a new beginning." We had made the new beginning. Now, I believed, we had to stay the course.